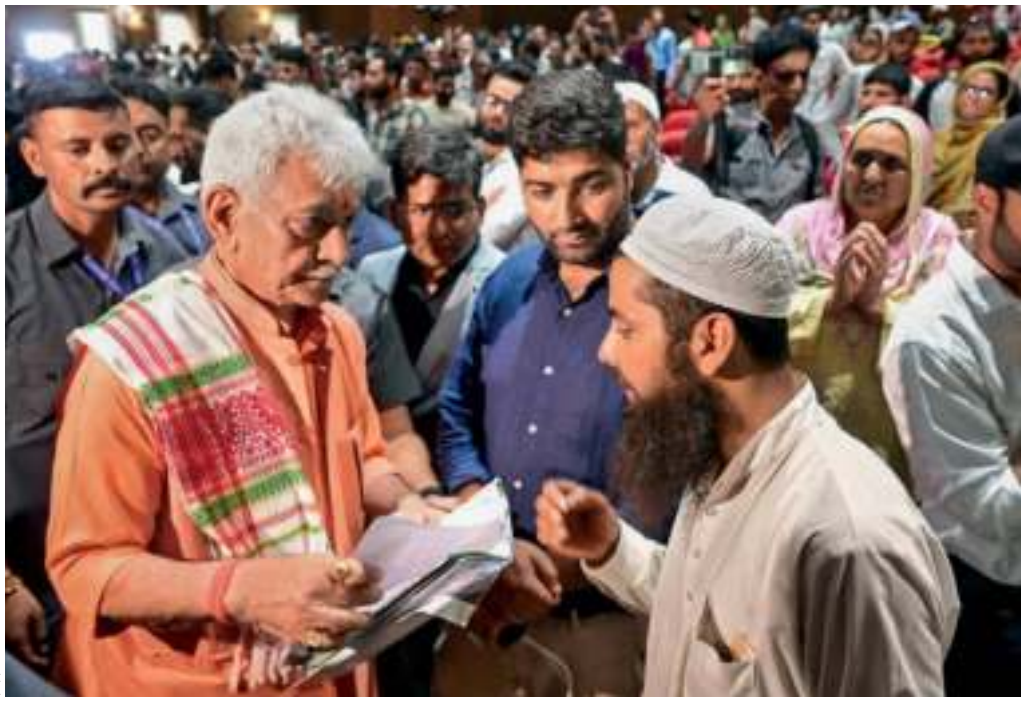


PTI

Stalked by terror and opprobrium for too long, victim families were "afraid of speaking about who had ruined their lives"

HEALING TOUCH LG Manoj Sinha distributes appointment letters to family members of terror attack victims in Baramulla district, Jul. 13

impaired man in 2012. Now 33, herself a mother to a girl and two sons, she was stalked all her life by penury. It is only now that a semblance of healing is coming to her.

THE FORGOTTEN ONES

The balm comes via a humane initiative from Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha. "LG saab listened to my ordeal like a father does with his children and promised relief," Kousar says, talking of her meeting with Sinha on June 29, alongside 119 other families, in Anantnag. The LG has launched a mission to rehabilitate the families left incurably wounded by three and a half decades of terrorism in Kashmir. This is a landscape littered with broken lives, but here's an unheralded subset of that. Families left with no recourse to justice or empathy on any side: no real compensation for their loss, no investigation as moral redemption.

Kashmir has an estimated 11,000 terror victim families; Hapatnar alone has 38. Save Youth, Save Future Foundation (SYSFF), an NGO that identified and documented these families, drew Sinha's attention to their ordeal last October. "Around 60 affected families met LG saab at Raj Bhawan in Srinagar. That wasn't easy, families were afraid of speaking about what and who ruined their lives," says Wajahat Farooq Bhat, chairman, SYSFF.

Takeaways

- **Kashmir has 11,000 or so terror victim families**
- **Shunned by state and society, justice eluded them for decades**
- **The LG's initiative will provide them jobs, loans**
- **Old cases to be probed**

'MY OWN FAMILY'

Now their fate is being rewritten, with LG Sinha mandating that investigations into old cases be reopened and expedited, and fresh FIRs lodged in incidents hitherto left untended. That's with a string of relief measures for each family: government jobs under the Jammu and Kashmir Compassionate Appointment Rules, 1994, and Rs 20 lakh to handhold startups under the Pradhan Mantri Mudra Yojana.

"I want to assure all terror victim families they are no different from my own family," LG Sinha said in Baramulla, offering the first tranche of appointment letters to the kin of about 50 terror victims on July 13, the scrapped Martyrs Day holiday that saw mobility curbs on Kashmir's key political leadership, including CM Omar Abdullah.

The initiative comes in the backdrop of the April 22 Pahalgam attack and unprecedented local protests against terrorism. Offering a never-imagined turnaround for the families, the response it's generating is revelatory. A special web portal, helplines and dedicated cells have been set up in all districts to help families register cases and claim rehabilitation. Over 2,000 applications have been received so far. "We are receiving hundreds of complaints even from the 1990s. In many cases, FIRs were not registered. No one will be spared," Sinha vowed. ■